

anything else that we absorb early on, unlearning this stuff is a serious undertaking.

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I can't analyze the money scripts my dad passed on to me without first looking at the ones he inherited from my grandmother, Meme. She's a Holocaust survivor, and the effects of her time in concentration camps have reverberated throughout our family. I've felt it in the whispers among my dad and his sister and my mom about "what happened to her."

When I was a little kid, I didn't appreciate Meme. She didn't dress like the other grandmothers—my sister's friends nicknamed her "Juicy" because she was as flashy and trendy as a pair of rhinestone Juicy sweatpants. She never acted like the other grandmothers either: she often ditched us for hair appointments or nice dinners with friends. I thought she was kind of mean. As I got older, I stopped taking her personality personally. Now I love goading her into giving me her harsh opinions on everything. She often calls me "a very interesting girl." It's not said with derision, but it's not said with pride either.

All my life, I've heard that Meme and her husband, Pepe, had a lot of money that they were withholding from the rest of the family. The implication was that we kids had to go through Meme to get to Pepe's money. She helped pay for bat mitzvah dresses and summers at sleepaway camp. But she also has strong views on when to lend (and when not to) that seem to lack a sense of empathy or selflessness. (I never got to ask Pepe about his finances before he died, but if I had, I don't think he would have been open to talking about them. It was probably something he'd view as uncouth.)

If Meme was boujee, then my mom's mom, Lee, was our working-class hero. A frequent source of sadness for me growing up was Lee's inability to move down to Florida from my mom's native New York to be close to us because she couldn't afford to quit her job. When I was a kid, I wrote a letter to her boss in crayon begging him to let her retire, a word I knew only because she and my mom talked about it endlessly. "It's not that Grandma doesn't love you," my mom would say. "She just can't retire yet."